# In-Depth Analysis of the Raw Deal CCG System

## Introduction

Raw Deal CCG is a collectible card game based on WWE (World Wrestling Entertainment) that simulates professional wrestling matches. Originally launched by Comic Images, the game has gone through multiple expansions and editions, maintaining its essence as a faithful representation of the WWE product in card game format.

This analysis examines in depth the strengths and weaknesses of the Raw Deal CCG game system, with the aim of identifying elements that can be improved or adapted for a new collectible card game. The analysis is based on a comprehensive review of the official rules manual (version 17, corresponding to the UNFORGIVEN expansion).

## Fundamental Game Structure

Raw Deal CCG is structured around several key components:

1. **Arsenal (Main Deck)**: A 60-card deck that represents the wrestler's abilities and moves.
2. **Superstar Card**: Card that represents the main character and determines special abilities.
3. **Backlash Deck**: Optional deck of up to 20 cards (10 Pre-match and 10 Mid-match) that simulates events before and during the match.
4. **Ring Area**: Zone where successfully played cards are placed.
5. **Ringside Pile**: Discard pile.

The objective of the game is to deplete the opponent's Arsenal, either through a "Pin Victory" (when the opponent must flip cards and cannot) or a "Count Out Victory" (when the opponent ends their turn with no cards in their Arsenal).

# Analysis of Strengths

## 1. Fortitude Mechanic

The Fortitude mechanic is perhaps the most brilliant innovation of the Raw Deal system. This mechanic represents the gradual increase in the wrestler's confidence and ability as the match progresses:

- **Natural Progression**: Players start with a Fortitude Rating of 0, forcing them to play basic cards at the beginning (with Fortitude Value of 0) and gradually build towards more powerful moves. This creates a natural narrative where the match escalates in intensity.
- **Strategic Decisions**: Players must constantly decide between playing low-damage cards to build Fortitude or saving more powerful cards for later moments. This tension between short and long term generates interesting decisions.
- **Thematic Fidelity**: The mechanic perfectly reflects how in real WWE matches, wrestlers begin with basic moves and gradually escalate towards their more spectacular finishers.
- **Pace Control**: Prevents players from using their most devastating moves from the beginning, creating a tension curve similar to a televised wrestling match.

The brilliance of this mechanic lies in how it perfectly fuses gameplay with theme, creating a system that is not only fun but "feels" like a WWE match.

## 2. Reversal System

The reversal mechanism is another significant strength that adds depth and interactivity to the game:

- **Constant Interactivity**: Unlike many card games where a player is passive during the opponent's turn, Raw Deal keeps both players constantly involved.
- **Dramatic Moments**: Reversals create moments of high tension, especially when a player manages to reverse a powerful move that could have defined the game.
- **System Duality**: The game offers two ways to reverse: from the hand (representing planned counterattacks) and by "overturning" (flipping cards from the deck, representing luck and instinct). This duality adds layers of strategic decision.

- **Thematic Simulation**: The system perfectly captures how in professional wrestling, a wrestler can counter an opponent's move, dramatically changing the course of the match.
- **Strategic Depth**: Players must constantly decide whether to use a reversal from their hand (guaranteed but limited) or risk finding one by overturning (uncertain but conserves resources).

This reversal system is fundamental to the Raw Deal experience, creating a dynamic game where fortunes can change quickly, similar to real WWE matches.

## 3. Thematic Fidelity

Raw Deal CCG stands out for its exceptional thematic integration with the WWE product:

- **Faithful Representation**: Cards and mechanics accurately reflect the wrestling styles and personalities of WWE Superstars, from characteristic moves to historic rivalries.
- **Style Diversity**: The different types of maneuvers (Strike, Grapple, Submission, High Risk, Trademark Finisher) represent the diversity of wrestling styles in WWE, allowing players to recreate the strategies of their favorite wrestlers.
- **Specific Abilities**: Each Superstar has unique abilities that capture their distinctive characteristics, making playing with different characters feel genuinely different.
- **Moral Alignments**: Heel (villain) and Face (hero) cards reflect the moral alignments of the characters, adding another layer of thematic fidelity.
- **Complete Narrative**: Pre-match and Mid-match mechanics simulate the narrative elements of WWE shows, from rivalries to special stipulations.

This thematic fidelity is not merely cosmetic but is deeply integrated into the game mechanics, creating an experience that resonates with WWE fans.

## 4. Variety and Customization

The game offers a wide range of customization options that encourage individual expression:

- **Superstar Diversity**: Multiple Superstars with unique abilities allow different play styles, from technical wrestlers to high-flying specialists or powerhouses.
- **Strategic Construction**: Deck construction (Arsenal and Backlash) offers strategic depth, allowing players to create decks that reflect their personal preferences.

- **Specific Cards**: Superstar-specific cards encourage thematic deck building, rewarding players who stay true to their character's identity.
- **Brand Divisions**: The division between Raw and SmackDown! adds another layer of identity to decks, reflecting the real WWE structure.
- **Pre-match Strategies**: Backlash cards allow pre-match strategies that affect the entire game, adding another dimension of customization.

This variety ensures that each player can find a style that appeals to them, significantly increasing replayability.

## 5. Innovative Mechanics

The game introduces several innovative mechanics that add depth and variety:

- **Stun Value (SV)**: Allows drawing cards when your opponent reverses your move by overturning, creating a compensation system that mitigates the frustration of seeing a move reversed.
- **Multi Cards**: Require multiple reversals to be completely neutralized, representing complex or devastating moves.
- **Chain and Volley**: Create sequences of interconnected plays, simulating the rapid exchanges of moves seen in real matches.
- **Follow-up Effects**: Simulate combinations of moves, rewarding players who plan specific sequences.
- **Hybrid Cards**: Can function as different types depending on the situation, adding tactical flexibility.

These innovative mechanics demonstrate the depth of Raw Deal's design, offering systems that go beyond the basic mechanics to create rich and varied gaming experiences.

## 6. Accessibility and Scalability

The game is designed to be initially accessible but with depth for experienced players:

- **Accessible Basic Rules**: The fundamental rules are relatively simple to learn, especially with the Quick Start Rulz section.
- **Functional Starter Decks**: The starter deck system allows immediate play without the need to build complex decks.

- **Gradual Complexity**: Advanced rules add complexity gradually, allowing players to deepen into the system at their own pace.
- **Expandable Structure**: The game design allows continuous thematic expansions, keeping the game fresh and updated with the WWE product.
- **Facilitated Entry**: The Quick Start Rulz facilitates the entry of new players, presenting the basic concepts without overwhelming with all the rules.

This combination of initial accessibility and long-term depth is a difficult balance to achieve in collectible card games and represents a significant strength of Raw Deal's design.

## Analysis of Weaknesses

### 1. Excessive Complexity

Despite its initial accessibility, the game suffers from a complexity that can be overwhelming:

- **Terminological Overload**: The number of terms, icons, and special effects (Active, Permanent, Universally Unique, Multi, Chain, Volley, Heat, etc.) can be excessive even for experienced players.
- **Complex Interactions**: Interactions between cards can create ambiguous rule situations that require interpretation or constant consultation of the manual.
- **Numerous Exceptions**: Exceptions to the rules are abundant and difficult to remember, creating confusion during the game.
- **Type Proliferation**: The number of card types and subtypes complicates learning and can intimidate new players.
- **Complexity Jump**: Advanced rules introduce too many new concepts simultaneously, creating a significant entry barrier.

This complexity can drive away potential players and make it difficult to retain casual players, limiting the growth of the player base.

## 2. Balance Issues

The system shows some fundamental balance problems:

- **Snowball Effect**: The dependence on Fortitude can create situations where a player who takes an early advantage accumulates so much Fortitude that they become practically unstoppable.
- **Superstar Imbalance**: Some Superstars may have significantly more powerful abilities than others, creating an inherent imbalance.
- **Unusable Cards**: High Fortitude cards can become permanently unusable if a player fails to build enough Fortitude, creating "dead weight" in the hand.
- **Decisive Randomness**: The randomness of overturning can decide games regardless of strategy, when a player is lucky enough to flip a reversal at the critical moment.
- **Strategic Imbalance**: The relative effectiveness of defensive versus offensive strategies is not always well calibrated, sometimes excessively favoring one style over another.

These balance issues can lead to frustrating gaming experiences and reduce long-term satisfaction.

## 3. Interactivity Limitations

Despite its interactive nature, there are significant limitations:

- **Off-Turn Passivity**: The player who doesn't have the turn is primarily limited to playing reversals, creating an asymmetry of participation.
- **Irreversible Cards**: Some specific cards cannot be reversed, limiting interaction and creating situations where a player must simply accept the damage.
- **Deterministic Pre-match**: The Pre-match phase can be too deterministic with little real interaction, functioning more as a preparation than as a genuinely interactive phase.
- **Forced Spectators**: Players with few reversal cards in hand may become mere spectators during long opponent turns.
- **Counterattack Limitation**: The "cannot reverse a reversal" mechanic limits counterattack possibilities, creating unilateral situations.

These limitations can reduce players' sense of agency and create moments of disconnection from the game.

## 4. Card Design Issues

The physical design of the cards presents some deficiencies:

- **Scattered Information**: Critical information is sometimes scattered across different parts of the card, making quick understanding difficult.
- **Textual Overload**: The amount of text on some cards can be excessive and difficult to process, especially during the game.
- **Insufficient Visual Distinction**: The visual distinction between some card types is not sufficiently clear, requiring detailed inspection.
- **Resolution Ambiguity**: Cards with multiple effects can create confusion about the order of resolution, leading to divergent interpretations.
- **Terminological Inconsistency**: Terminology is not always consistent between different expansions, creating unnecessary confusion.

These design issues can negatively affect the gaming experience, especially for new players.

## 5. Thematic Limitations

Despite its strong thematic integration, there are significant limitations:

- **Underdeveloped Tag Teams**: The representation of tag team matches is less developed than individual matches, despite their importance in WWE.
- **Underrepresented Elements**: Some important aspects of WWE, such as external interference or personality changes, are underrepresented in the mechanics.
- **Scripted Narrative**: The mechanics don't capture well the narrative and scripted nature of professional wrestling, which is fundamentally different from a genuine sporting competition.
- **Brand Restrictions**: The strict divisions between Raw and SmackDown! limit creative possibilities, especially considering that in real WWE wrestlers change brands.
- **Moral Simplification**: The binary distinction between Heel and Face doesn't reflect the complexity of modern WWE characters, who often operate in moral gray areas.

These limitations reduce complete thematic fidelity and represent missed opportunities for deeper integration with the WWE product.

## 6. Long-term Accessibility Issues

The game presents significant barriers to player retention:

- **Steep Learning Curve**: The increasing complexity can discourage casual players, creating a barrier to continued participation.
- **Acquisition Pressure**: The need to constantly acquire new cards to remain competitive can be costly and discouraging.
- **Expansive Complexity**: The increasing complexity with each expansion makes it difficult to keep up with all the rules and interactions.
- **WWE Knowledge Dependence**: Full appreciation of the game requires familiarity with the WWE product, limiting its appeal to broader audiences.
- **Digital Absence**: The lack of an official digital system limits accessibility in the modern era, where many card games have a digital presence.

These issues can limit sustained growth of the player base and the longevity of the game.

## 7. Game Pace Issues

The pace of the game can be problematic in several aspects:

- **Prolonged Games**: Games can be excessively long due to the overturning mechanic, which requires physically manipulating many cards.
- **Unbalanced Turns**: A player's turns can extend too much if they manage to chain multiple cards, creating an uneven experience.
- **Disconnected Pre-match**: The Pre-match phase can feel like a separate game that delays the main action, creating a sense of discontinuity.
- **Slow Resolution**: Resolving complex effects can significantly slow down the game, especially when there are multiple effects interacting.
- **Constant Calculation**: The need to constantly calculate Fortitude interrupts the flow of the game, creating frequent pauses.

These pace issues can negatively affect the overall experience, especially in a casual context or with time limitations.

# Recommendations for Improvements

Based on the analysis of strengths and weaknesses, here are specific recommendations to improve the system in a new collectible card game:

## 1. Strategic Simplification

- **Reduce Card Types**: Consolidate some card types to reduce complexity without sacrificing strategic depth.
- **Unify Terminology**: Create a more consistent and reduced lexicon to facilitate learning.
- **Clear Iconography**: Develop a more intuitive icon system that reduces dependence on extensive text.
- **Tiered Rules**: Implement a more gradual learning system, with clearly defined levels of complexity.

## 2. Improved Balance

- **Anti-Snowball Mechanism**: Introduce mechanics that allow lagging players to recover, such as bonuses for the player who is losing.
- **Superstar Balancing**: Ensure all characters have comparable abilities in power, though different in style.
- **Universal Utility**: Design cards that maintain some utility even when they cannot be played due to Fortitude restrictions.
- **Controlled Randomness**: Reduce the impact of luck at critical moments, possibly allowing more control over overturning.

## 3. Greater Interactivity

- **Off-Turn Actions**: Expand the options available to the player who doesn't have the turn, beyond just reversals.
- **Universal Reversals**: Ensure almost all cards have some way of being countered, maintaining interactivity.
- **Interactive Pre-match**: Redesign the Pre-match phase to include more meaningful decisions and interaction between players.
- **Counterattack System**: Allow some limited form of responding to reversals, creating additional layers of interaction.

## 4. Optimized Card Design

- **Centralized Information**: Reorganize information on cards for greater clarity and readability.

- **Concise Text**: Reduce the amount of text on cards, using more icons and standardized terms.
- **Clear Visual Distinction**: Improve visual distinction between card types to facilitate quick identification.
- **Effect Hierarchy**: Establish clear rules about the order of resolution of multiple effects.

## 5. Thematic Expansion

- **Robust Tag Team System**: Develop more complete mechanics to represent tag team matches.
- **Narrative Elements**: Incorporate more elements that reflect the narrative nature of WWE, such as alignment changes or interference.
- **Brand Flexibility**: Allow greater flexibility between Raw and SmackDown!, reflecting the reality of WWE.
- **Moral Complexity**: Introduce a more nuanced system than the binary Heel/Face, possibly with neutral or changing alignments.

## 6. Improved Accessibility

- **Complementary Digital Application**: Develop an application that facilitates tracking rules, calculations, and effects.
- **Accessible Economic Model**: Design a card acquisition model less dependent on constant purchase of expansions.
- **Integrated Tutorials**: Include learning materials within the game itself, such as reference cards or tutorial scenarios.
- **Partial Thematic Independence**: Make the game appreciable even without deep knowledge of WWE, maintaining the theme but making it more accessible.

## 7. Pace Optimization

- **Streamlined Mechanics**: Redesign overturning to reduce physical manipulation of cards.
- **Turn Limits**: Establish natural limits to turn duration to avoid extreme imbalances.
- **Pre-match Integration**: Better integrate the Pre-match phase with the main game for a more cohesive experience.
- **Simplified Resolution**: Simplify the resolution of complex effects to maintain game pace.
- **Calculation Aids**: Provide physical or digital tools to facilitate Fortitude tracking.

# Conclusion

Raw Deal CCG presents a fundamentally solid system with innovative mechanics that brilliantly capture the essence of WWE. Its main strengths lie in the Fortitude mechanic, the reversal system, thematic fidelity, and strategic variety. However, it suffers from excessive complexity, balance issues, limitations in interactivity, and suboptimal card design.

A new collectible card game based on Raw Deal CCG should maintain its fundamental strengths while addressing its weaknesses through strategic simplification, better balance, greater interactivity, optimized design, thematic expansion, improved accessibility, and game pace optimization.

With these improvements, it would be possible to create a game that maintains the essence and depth of Raw Deal CCG while offering a more accessible, balanced, and satisfying experience for a wide range of players.